Everyone is busy building intelligence, but no one can define what it is

In their books, Karen Hao, Max Fisher, and Dwarkesh Patel explore the AI industry that has become a juggernaut even as it still struggles to define intelligence, measure its costs, or agree on its end goal

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American journalist and author Karen Hao spent years reporting from inside and around OpenAI, and what she found was less a portrait of a company and more an autopsy of the larger idea of artificial general intelligence (AGI).

OpenAI was founded on the premise that if AGI was coming regardless, it was better to have safety and ethics-conscious researchers at the frontier than to cede it to those with fewer compunctions. The CEO, Sam Altman, even went as far as to design the company's board such that it could fire him too if he ever came in the way of its core mission. That board, briefly did fire him, but reversed the decision quickly. Hao traces this arc not as a scandal, but as something inevitable; as an outcome of the ideas that come from Silicon Valley founders who have vast resources and the freedom to push boundaries. OpenAI is described in the early chapters of her book, Empire of AI, as "a rare intellectual playground without strings attached, a haven for fringe ideas." By the time she finished reporting, it had become one of the most powerful and least accountable corporations on earth.

No clear definition

What is artificial intelligence? Alan Turing's 1950 paper is widely considered the founding document of AI. In it, he begins with the question, "Can machines think?" and quickly reframes it as the imitation game. He proposes that any machine with the ability to convince a human of its sentience more than 30% of the time, passes his test. He never defined what intelligence really is. By his test, most agentic AI models today seem to "think". But what thinking actually is, remains unresolved, even among those who have staked billions on replicating it.

Hao spends a chapter of her book trying to pin down a definition of intelligence with impressive intensity. The AI industry's working answer, for now, borrows from the "pure language" hypothesis: the idea that all human knowledge is encoded in language, and that AGI might therefore emerge from language alone. The cost for training a generative AI model is already approaching a billion dollars, and projections for the coming years are only shooting up. All this money is being spent on a process whose foundation and end goal both remain largely unarticulated.

The consequences

Max Fisher, in The Chaos Machine, shows us that this pattern is not new, but that its consequences have grown manifold. While Fisher's book is ostensibly about social media algorithms and radicalisation, it also holds up a clear mirror to what happens when a technology that shapes human behaviour is deployed before anyone has asked what it is shaping us towards.

The early conventional wisdom about platforms such as Facebook, he argues, vastly understated their power. Their algorithms amplify moral fury, compress complexity into viral fragments rewarded with small doses of digital dopamine, and make polarisation not a bug but an intended, even celebrated, output.

By the time insiders began to acknowledge this, the architecture was global and deeply embedded. Facebook's founding president, Sean Parker, eventually admitted the goal was to consume as much of conscious human time and attention as possible. By then, a billion people were already inside the wormhole.

Max Fisher wrote about a previous technological wave, but there are parallels in the inherited arrogance. The same incentives — engagement maximisation, attention as a commodity, and uncontrolled growth as the only metric of success — now underpin the expansion of AI. Fisher's book, read alongside Hao's reporting, gives readers both a long view and a more immediate story: this pattern has played out before, and in building disruptive technologies, their makers are often aware of the very real human cost of progress — and continue anyway. To be clear, neither author rejects scientific progress, but both hold up an important mirror to what it costs to get there.

The God complex

Dwarkesh Patel's The Scaling Era is an oral history stitched together with conversations with researchers, engineers, and thinkers who made the last six years of AI possible. Unlike Hao and Fisher, Patel and his interviewees are not cynical of AI. They are, for the most part, people who believe they are doing something necessary and sacred even as they do acknowledge its shortcomings. For instance, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei in the book says that if agentic AI were to become super powerful and wreak havoc, "we'd have basically no ability to stop it."

The God complex here is not megalomaniacal in the conventional sense; it is more subtle. It is the conviction that because the intelligence being built is unprecedented, the ordinary human frameworks of accountability, consent, and cost-distribution can be changed too.

Patel's book is highly technical, diving into the scalability of AI models and what intelligence is. Curiously, both Hao and he touch on this question and seem to conclude that there is still no unified definition of "intelligence" or "thinking.".

Altman in particular, who is the primary subject of Hao's book, has signed up for Nectome, a startup whose premise is that the brain can be chemically preserved at death to be digitally uploaded to a server later. This is where the pure language hypothesis and the God complex finally converge. If all human knowledge is in language, and language can be extracted and replicated, then perhaps consciousness too can be preserved, transferred, and ultimately made everlasting. The question Turing called too meaningless to discuss has become the basis of an afterlife business. The arrogance is not

in the ambition itself; it is in the certainty that whatever the “tech bros” of Silicon Valley end up building will be the answer.

Paying a price

In the meantime, as Hao sharply points out, communities in South American countries are paying a hefty price right now, with their water and land resources. The AI we have has already reshaped medicine, science, and daily life in useful ways. But the industry is not focused on refinement or more environment-friendly improvements to what already exists; it is aiming at something much larger.

What these three books produce, read together, is less a verdict on AI and more a map of its (often) unacknowledged shortcomings. Hao calls these companies an empire — ruthless in their conquest like royal empires of the bygone era. Scaling, discussed in great technical detail in Patel’s book, asks an important question: what happens when we run out of data to train models on? Billions of dollars are being spent per model, land and water are being taken to replicate millions of years of evolutionary biology, but to what end? That remains unclear.

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